Google doles out Raspberry Pis to students

In an effort to boost coding knowledge among school children, Google has announced a generous grant, through which 15,000 Raspberry Pi Model B mini computers will reach school kids in the UK. The Raspberry Pi Foundation will be giving away these mini computers after selecting the children they believe would benefit from the Raspberry Pi. Google's executive chairman, Eric Schmidt, along with Raspberry Pi founder, Eben Upton, visited Cambridge, and taught coding to local kids in a classroom recently.

With Google's grant, more students will have access to the Raspberry Pi, which will help them get hands-on knowledge in a varied range of educational open source code. As to how the Raspberry Pi Foundation will shortlist students, "We're going to be working with Google and six UK educational partners to find the kids who we think will benefit from having their very own Raspberry Pi. CoderDojo, Code Club, Computing at Schools, Generating Genius, Teach First and OCR will each be helping us identify those kids, and will also be helping us work with them," the Raspberry Pi site reported.

Initiatives like these indicate that big companies like Google understand the importance of imparting quality education to future innovators. With this grant, Google clearly showcased that it cannot wait for governments to take serious steps to build our future. "We're incredibly grateful for Google's help in something that we, like them, think is of vital importance. We think they deserve an enormous amount of credit for helping some of our future engineers and scientists find a way to a career they're going to love," the posting on the Raspberry Pi site added.

A new map editor for OpenStreetMap

The OpenStreetMap project has got a new Web-based map editor dubbed as iD editor from MapBox. The map editor is based on JavaScript and the D3.js data visualisation library, and has been added in this alpha release. The Knight Foundation had issued a grant back in September, which funded the development of the new map editor. The new iD editor will replace the OpenStreetMap project's current editor, Potlatch 2. The iD editor, which was developed in association with the author of Potlatch 2, Richard Fairhurst, doesn't require Flash to run.

The OpenStreetMap editor is mainly employed to bring in updates to existing maps. Developers can add new roads, buildings and landmarks, based either on a user's recorded GPS traces, or manually, by detecting aerial imagery, which is available for the OpenStreetMap project. So, with an easier map editor, existing developers would be able to draw new contributors to the project, and the map data set will significantly improve.

Meet NanoWatch—a Linux watch-cum-phone

Dumb wrist watches are getting smarter with time. Taiwan-based WiMe has introduced its smart watch, dubbed the NanoWatch, which includes support for voice calls. This means, you can make voice calls from your watch and not just talk to your buddies. You can even listen to music as it includes a Yamaha music chip. Priced at US$ 99, the NanoWatch runs on embedded Linux and sports a 3.9-cm (1.54-inch) resistive touch LCD with a 240x240 pixel resolution. The NanoWatch measures 51.6 mm x 38 mm x 10.2 mm in size and comes with 256 MB ROM, a 4 GB internal microSD card, and a SIM card slot WiMe supplies a headset, a wristband, a micro USB cable and a clipper along with its NanoWatch. You can either wear the watch or can hang it on your neck and even clip the watch to your shirt.

Enjoy Windows apps on Android!

Here's news for techies with Android gadgets who wish to have a Windows OS experience. You can now run Windows apps on Android-based smartphones and tablets. Wine for Linux is soon going to establish itself on mobile devices and will be dubbed as Wine for Android. If you are new to Wine, here is a brief introduction. Wine is open source software, which allows Windows-based applications to run on UNIX-based operating systems.

To be more precise, its compatibility layer allows Windows applications to run on POSIX-compliant operating systems like Linux, Mac OSX and BSD. Wine functions differently; instead of simulating internal Windows logic like a virtual machine or emulator, the open source software translates Windows API calls into POSIX calls on the go, thus offering better performance.